



Serene atmosphere: Set amid open land near Rajkot, the Sanosara Cricket Pavilion hosted Vijay Hazare Trophy fixtures in surroundings far removed from the usual domestic bustle.

ANISH PATHIYIL

Kanchan nodded in agreement. During the stay, they kept a close watch on Yashasvi's routine, preparing his meals and making sure he ate on time. "With his job involving a lot of travel, keeping his diet consistent becomes important," the father said.

Yashasvi rang in the New Year with his parents and later shared pictures on social media. Back after a break, it was much-needed family time for the young batter in a home away from home.

Shayan Acharya

A picturesque set-up

Situated around 40 kilometres from the city of Rajkot, almost halfway to Jamnagar, the village of Laiyali houses the Saurashtra Cricket Association's Sanosara Cricket Pavilion.

The complex, inaugurated by the then BCCI secretary Jay Shah in early 2024, hosted fixtures from Group B

of the Vijay Hazare Trophy in 2025.

The state-of-the-art facility provides one of the most captivating visual frames across domestic cricket in India. The view from two storeys up captures the lush green outfields of the playing surface, outlined by a vast expanse of barren land punctuated by scattered trees and a spattering of houses. On the horizon sits a band of blue, radiating from a small lake located nearby.

The pavilion also offers a vantage point from which live action on both adjacent grounds can be enjoyed. The Diary was at the stadium to watch Baroda take on Hyderabad on the 'B' ground.

With Nitya Pandya and Amit Pasi combining for what felt like a never-ending opening partnership of 230 runs, an opportunity presented itself to take a short walk across the terrace and catch a glimpse of a 229-Test-wicket veteran delivering one of his trademark new-ball spells.

While the brief detour proved rewarding, with Mohammed Shami picking up two wickets in his first three overs, it was Akash Deep and Mukesh Kumar who ran through the Jammu and Kashmir batting order, bundling it out for 63. The Diary

attempted to take a second glance after Baroda piled up 417 in its batting effort, only to find that the players had long since left the venue after Bengal chased down the target in a trice.

The law of averages caught up with the Bengal pacers during their contest against Hyderabad at the Niranjan Shah Stadium a few days later. Aman Rao, just three matches into his List A career, toyed with the internationals to bludgeon his way to a double century. Volunteers were forced to shuttle from one empty stand to another on the lower deck to retrieve the ball after his six-hitting barrage.

The 21-year-old brought out a fingers-interlocked 'mask' celebration after reaching the landmark, reminiscent of Arsenal striker Victor Gyokeres. At the end of the game, he explained that it was a reaction to show that he 'was unknown so far but had now arrived'.

He did, however, confirm to the Diary that he is a fan of the North London club. For a Manchester United supporter, that was, unfortunately, a few brownie points lost.

Anish Pathiyil